Beirut

By Alan Bowne

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: Torch has tested positive for the AIDS virus and has been quarantined with other "positives" in the Lower East Side of Manhattan, which is patrolled by guards and fenced off from the rest of the city. Torch has been tattooed with a decal proclaiming his status as a "positive".

ACTOR: Blue is in love with him and sneaks past the guards to visit him. To escape detection, she has had a false decal pasted to her body so that she will appear to be a "positive," too.

TOGETHER: Beirut by Alan Bowne

TORCH: What if you die from it, Blue? And I gotta live with that?

BLUE: Come over here.

TORCH: Answer me!

BLUE: Come over here and I'll tell you.

TORCH: Tell me from there! I wanna hear this. How I can sit here and watch you shrivel up like a raisin. Sit here and watch you lose like 50 pounds in 24 hours. While your head! Puffs up! To twice its size! And that I done it to you. This I wanna hear. (Beat)

BLUE: You want pizza? You got pizza. With this decal I can sneak out and sneak in. You want stickball? You got it. Wanna get drunk? Wanna nice t-shirt? It's all yours. And if one of us starts to die? Then a light meal, and a glass of wine. (Beat as he stares at her) We could go to sleep in each other's arms.

TORCH: (Staring) You gonna get serious? Or what?

BLUE: I am serious.

TORCH: I could really see this. Oh sure. You and me playin house in here. On Sundays we take a little stroll inna park. You seen Tomkins Square lately? It's where they pile the bodies. And burn 'em on Sundays. We could walk around, sniffin the fresh air. We could watch the people who can't control themselves? Squattin in the gutters. Or! We could go to the Laundromat on Avenue A? And watch people trying to unglue the t-shirts from their sores to wash 'em. It's the American dream!

BLUE: I usta think that too.

TORCH: Think what?

BLUE: That life was over here, and death was way over there. That they don't mix. But now? They're joined at the hip.

TORCH: What we need here! Is some adult maturity!

BLUE: It's a lovely thing you're feelin for me. How you don't wanna infect me and all? But that's just ridiculous, all right?

TORCH: I ain't lissenin no more!

BLUE: Because I got two choices. First, I can live without risk and feel dead. Or second? I can risk death and feel alive. I would not be the woman who fell for and idiot like you if I would choose the first..

TORCH: Suicide! Is a sin! It's anti-nature. Un-Italian! And non-American! (Beat)

BLUE: You had a choice about getting this disease? Or you had one word to say about one thing that has happened to you in your whole life, including you got born? No. it was always other people or god or somebody else that made your choices. You ain't owned one minute of

your life. Torch. But that moment you die? You can choose it. You can choose when, you can choose how. You own it, Torch. You don't wanna give me a baby? O.K. Then give me that moment. That moment when we die. It will belong to us, Torch, and to nobody else. (Beat) All I'm sayin, is it don't have to be a sin!

TORCH: You end up in hell!

BLUE: Oh my god! (Looking about in mock-terror at the sleazy room) How will be handle it?

TORCH: Shut up! And go home.

BLUE: So. That's settled. I'm gonna get curtains for in here. And as for that guard? I know what to do about him. Got the idea from this TV program they showed the other night, NBC, coast to coast, about plagues like in Europe hundreds of years ago? This was supposed to make us. Feel better? I dunno. Anyway, they told how the people who got the Black Death? A more Christian disease than what we got now, I mean you died in a matter of mere days. How these people who caught it got very pissed off about the ones who didn't catch it. So the sick ones would sit by their front windows until well person passed by on the street? And then suddenly reach out! Grab them! And breathe into their faces! People. Never. Change. (Beat; chuckling). So that's what I'll do to that guard. When he comes by, I'll ask him to come closer. And then breathe on him!

TORCH: This thing here is not airborne! It's a fluid transmission only!

BLUE: Thank you, doctor. So I'll spit on him! We can always scare him off, scare him so bad he'll stop bothering us. There's power in being sick, Torch! (Beat)

TORCH: Blue?

BLUE: Yeah? Come here. I want you to look. In the candlelight? There's these little specks floatin in the air. Little animals just waiting. TO kill off the things that get weak. They float and turn and dance in the light. Come on. Look.

TORCH: No.

BLUE: O.K., so here comes a microbe! (She approaches TORCH with mock menace)

TORCH: Stop it!

BLUE: I'm a germ! I'm gonna kill you!

TORCH: You cant' do this!

BLUE: Call out the National Guard!

TORCH: You gonna haveta do this, Blue, all by yourself. (Big, emphatic) It ain't. My. Responsibility! (Beat)

BLUE: You wimp of a cop-out!

TORCH: Huh?

BLUE: I bet you been telling that to girls. Your whole life!

TORCH: What is that suppose to mean?

BLUE: Men? Are worthless!

TORCH: Who?

BLUE: Always like – (Sarcastic macho mimicry) She begged me for it! Wadn't my fault if she got hurt! Stupid chick! I can just see you! If

I come down with this? You gonna be crawlin around here goin. It wadn't me. She asked for it. I was just this. Innocent bystander!

TORCH: Jesus, I never met such a hypocrite! So we won't do it! So get outa here!

BLUE: You say it.

TORCH: Say what?

BLUE: That you want me! (Beat) That what you feel, I gotta feel. That what I gotta face, you gotta face. (Beat)

TORCH: You are some kina fool. Some kina magazine. Like Modern Romance, like Teenage Love, like -- How'd I ever fall in love with you? In the middle! Of a disease????

BLUE: Piss on this love you got! I don't want excuses here, Torch.

TORCH: So what do you want?

BLUE: I want you to be with me. And never leave (Beat)

TORCH: I get it. You want my soul, right?

BLUE: That's right

TORCH: Typical woman.

BLUE: That's right

TORCH: Sex ain't enough for you, hey?

BLUE: Good-bye. (Contemptuously)

TORCH: How can this be? You love somebody and don't wanna give 'em a disease? And that makes you this. Sonofabitch?

BLUE: Pre-plague? You woulda said, Hey you! You getting' all hung-up and hurt here? So it's your own fault, you idiot!

TORCH: It's not the same!

BLUE: It's the same. (Rummages in her purse and throws packs of cigarettes at him) Here's some extra cigarettes. And somewhere. In here. I brung you a mars bar.

TORCH: Under your thumb, that's where you want us. In a cage which only you got the key! Well, lemme tell you, with a guy? It's different! He wants a good time, a few laughs, and then. He wants. To go out. And play some pool! (Beat)

BLUE: What. Are you talking about?

TORCH: We'd be trapped here! Lookin for spots on each other alla time. I can't live with you, Blue, in some kina romatic magazine. Even if I forget and drink outa the same glass as you? Much less bee with you? I would hate myself.

BLUE: Guys always do.

TORCH: Do what?

BLUE: Hate themselves after having sex. You guys can have this 4th of July experience with a woman and still feel like total crap afterwards. What is that?

TORCH: You keep changing! The subject!

BLUE: The subject! Is you are afraid!

TORCH: What? I don't wanna murder you! Is that O.K.?

BLUE: No, I won't accept that.

TORCH: It's the truth!

BLUE: I gotta go.

TORCH: What, I'm some kina wimp! Cause I don't wanna fill you with parvoviroids?

BLUE: Stop all this virus mumbo! What you don't want. Is me. A human being on your hands who might feel pan. Or make a demand. Or need you when there's nothing left. (Beat)

TORCH: That! Is totally. And complete. Bullshit!

BLUE: Torch, I didn't risk my life to come here for a visit! I came to live with you, maybe even to die with you. I didn't know what I'd find. Would your skin be smooth and white, like before, or would you be covered with sores? I didn't know. And I didn't care (Beat)

TORCH: (Pleading) Blue - -

BLUE: Fine . . . . . Die alone.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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